

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Human rights

BEFORE

1776 The US Declaration of Independence articulates “certain unalienable Rights.”

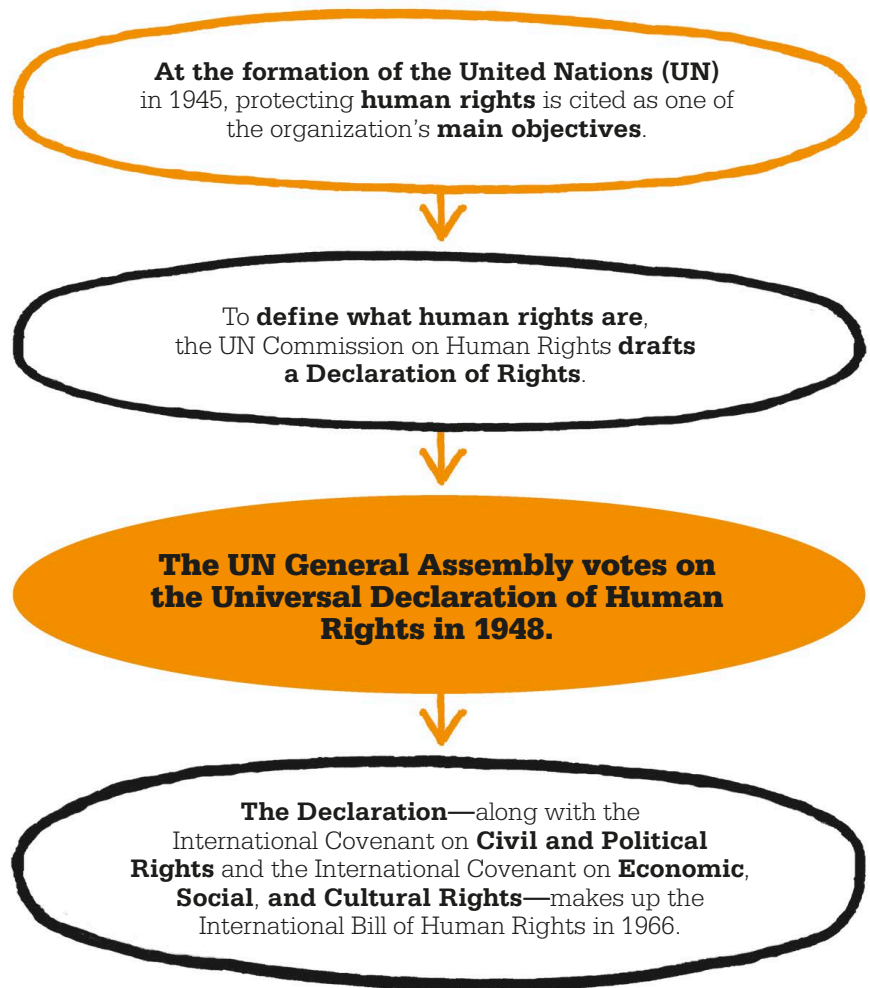
1789 The Declaration of the Rights of Man and of the Citizen is adopted by the National Constituent Assembly of revolutionary France.

AFTER

1950 The European Convention on Human Rights (ECHR) is drafted.

1965 The International Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Racial Discrimination is adopted by the United Nations (UN).

1979 The Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination Against Women is opened for signature.



Prior to 1948's Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR), there was no general statement in international law on what protections people were entitled to by virtue of simply being human. At the end of the 18th century, the French and American Revolutions fought against the established institutions of power and, inspired by works such as Thomas Paine's *Rights of Man* in 1791, began to advance the idea of human rights. The 1807 abolition of the slave trade in the British Empire and advances in the rights of working

people in the late 18th and early 19th centuries were important in creating the idea that everyone was entitled to a basic standard of fair treatment. In the aftermath of World War I, the Treaty of Versailles and the establishment of the League of Nations made further contributions through recognizing the idea of minority rights.

It is worth pointing out here that human rights law should not be confused with humanitarian law, which focuses on the conduct of warfare and the treatment of civilians. Before World War II, major international humanitarian treaties

included the Geneva Conventions of 1864, 1906, and 1929, and the Hague Conventions of 1899 and 1907. Although the two categories of law share concerns about the treatment of people, today they are separate branches of law.

The UDHR was the most significant moment in the creation of human rights as a form of international law. By 2020, it had been translated into 523 languages and, while not legally binding, it was to reshape international law. It set out a series of protections that all countries ought to provide for their citizens. It was a key factor